



Statue of Frey
The Vikings worshipped Frey, the Norse god of fertility. This statue from Sweden shows Frey holding his beard—a symbol of growth and virility.

Thor's hammer pendant
Thor's hammer—a symbol of power and virility—was a common theme for jewelry. Thor was the Norse god of thunder.



gold beading and wire work



Gold arm ring
Decorated with patterns made by stamping, beading, and minute engraving, this arm ring from Råbylille, Denmark, has crosses and tree motifs.

sword indicates that rider is a warrior



Silver figure of horseman
This stylized metal figure from Sweden probably represents a warrior on horseback. The Vikings were fine horsemen, but they preferred to travel by ship.



ends of ring are in shape of cat heads

THE VIKINGS

THE ARTISTRY AND SKILL OF VIKING ARTISANS BELIES THEIR REPUTATION AS SAVAGES

Between the 8th and 11th centuries, the Viking world spanned Europe, from the Pontic Steppes in the south and east to the shores of North America in the west and north. This realm was tied together by a culture of arts and crafts.

The unifying motifs of Viking art and crafts were elaborate ornamentation, interlacing patterns, and stylized animals. The material culture of the Vikings was mostly utilitarian yet finely crafted. Common, ceremonial, and military objects were ornamented heavily. Techniques such as etching, engraving, and inlaying and the use of metal beading helped to create patterns of interweaving tendrils, "gripping beasts," and stylized limbs.

buckle plate for securing baldric

baldric (slinglike shoulder strap)



Silver brooch/pin
This gold-coated silver brooch or cloak pin from Sweden is highlighted with niello, a black metallic compound.

double-edged blade

Sword
Swords were rare and extremely valuable for the Vikings. This sword could be easily drawn out from its sheath and wielded with one hand.

Wooden shield
Shields were made from spruce, fir, pine, or linden wood with iron handles behind an iron boss. They were painted with bright colors and often had intricate designs.

colors signified intent or allegiance



sturdy wooden haft with runic inscription



iron blade

Ax
Axes were commonly used by poor Vikings, as they were cheaper than swords. This Danish ax has a metal blade and a wooden haft.